

India's new Army chief takes over at a time when the force's battle readiness is low and a series of scandals have dented its image

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

It was a routine function organised by the 4 Corps which guards India's sensitive North-east in the garrison town of Tezpur last year.

R.B. Srivastava, then director of Defence Research & Development Organisation's (DRDO) research laboratory, got talking with Lt-General Vijay Kumar Singh, the Eastern Army Commander. The topic steered to Iron Removal Units (IRU), washing machine-sized devices that filter out iron from the groundwater in the North-east. The first IRUs had done well after being introduced two years ago, removing metals which caused hair loss and gastric trouble among troops.

Returning to his headquarters in Kolkata's Fort William, the Eastern Army Commander ordered 100 IRU units for immediate distribution among forward deployed soldiers in the North-east, simultaneously urging the DRDO to begin developing water bottle-size portable filtration units. His drop-in-the-ocean gesture may have gone unnoticed in times when the term boots-on-the-ground is used so loosely that nobody pays attention to the feet that go into them.

But not for nothing is Vijay Kumar Singh, 59, the new Chief of the Army Staff, known as the soldier's general. The first commando army chief (he has a cameo in Nana Patekar's commando-centric 1991 film *Prahaar*), the straight-talking barrel-chested officer with a booming laugh and piercing brown eyes is a third-generation soldier from Bapora village near Bhiwani in Haryana. His father was a Lt-Colonel and his grandfather a Subedar Major in the British Indian Army. As the 26th chief of the army staff, Singh now helms an army that is

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